

Building a Design Pipeline with AI

Company	Runwayz
Role	Head of Product
Tools	Claude VS Code Google Stitch Figma + Figma MCP
Team	2 Designers 2 Engineers CEO
Year	2026

Charlie Donnelly

OUTLINE

TIMELINE

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```

Redesign edit modals for...

Redesign edit modals for onboarding exp...

1. I defer to your judgement

2. keep semantic

✓ Capture light mode to Figma

✓ Capture dark mode to Figma

✓ Populate Art Deco variable collection in Figma

✓ Build talent-flow-v2.html with all 13 screens

Built talent-flow-v2.html — all 13 screens in one gallery, Art Deco tokens throughout.

Key decisions applied:

• Dashboard hero → charcoal-900 surface + sunset CTA button (warmer, more Art Deco, stays AA)

• Page bg → cream/default #FAF4E6 ; sheets stay white for contrast

• Teal primaries → accent/default #14609F (AA on cream)

• Chips → accent-bg/accent for input pills, success-bg/success for status, charcoal-900 for "Overtime Flex"

• Form focus → 2px blue-700 border + blue-700 glow ring

• Typography → Figtree throughout (400/500/600/700/800)

• Section labels → uppercase, letter-spaced, charcoal-500 (matches poster-label feel)

• "Done" / "In Progress" → jade + tangerine semantic, kept as requested

Open to feedback on:

1. Hero placement — the sunset-on-charcoal reads bold; let me know if you want a quieter treatment (cream-hero surface + jet-blue CTA instead)

2. Edit sheet chip style — I used accent-bg pills with an X; if you'd rather keep them grey-neutral, easy swap

⌘ Esc to focus or unfocus Claude

1

+ []

runwayz-art-deco-token...

</> Edit automati...

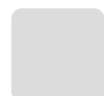
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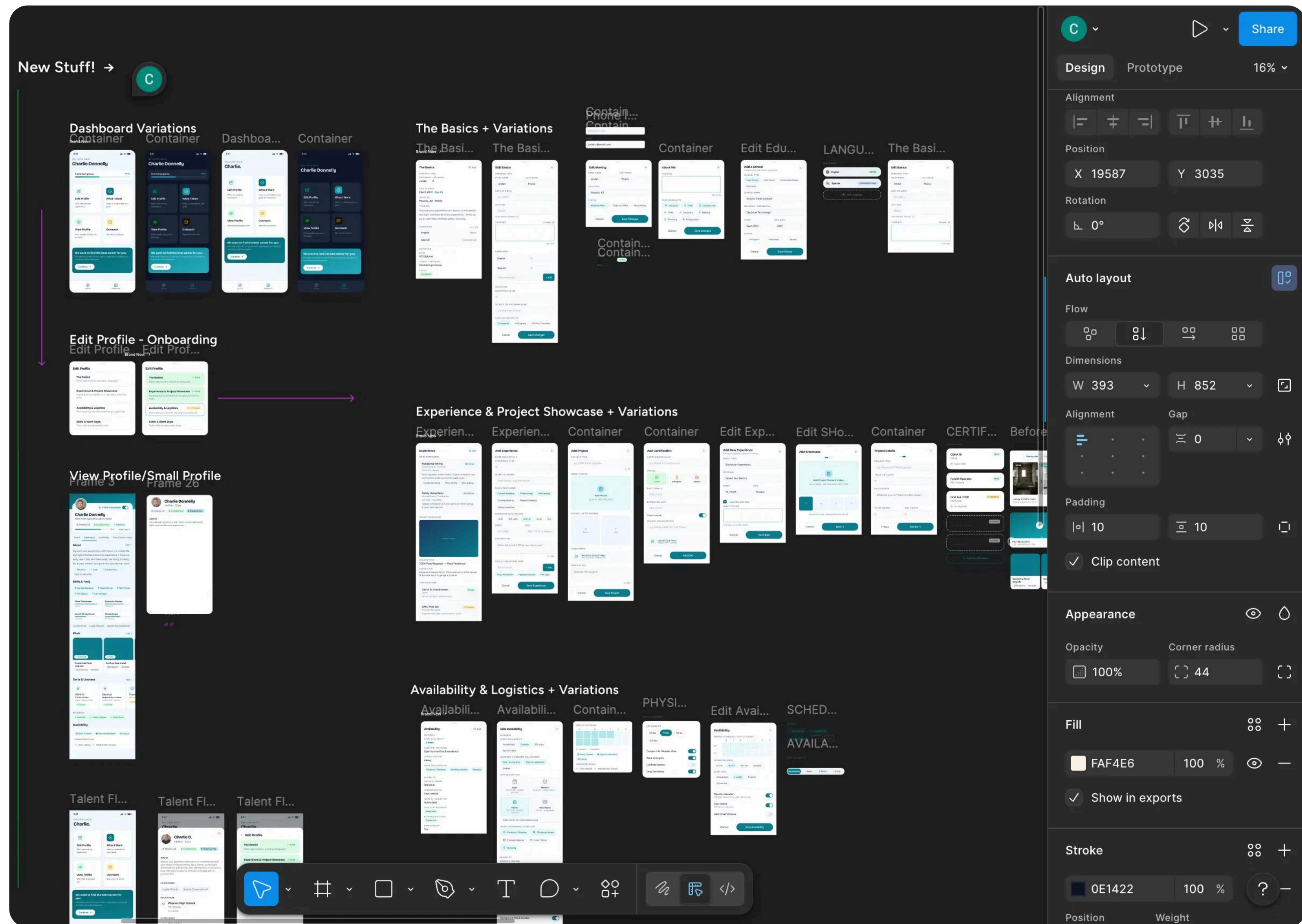
Setting the Stage.

Runwayz decided to re-invest in their software product at a time where *AI design and development tooling could get us from 0-1 faster than ever.*

Immediately this created a new risk: *design and discovery becoming a bottleneck* for development.

My question as Head of Product: *how do we let development move as fast as possible without design slowing it down,* or worse, without AI stripping the Runwayz brand of authenticity?



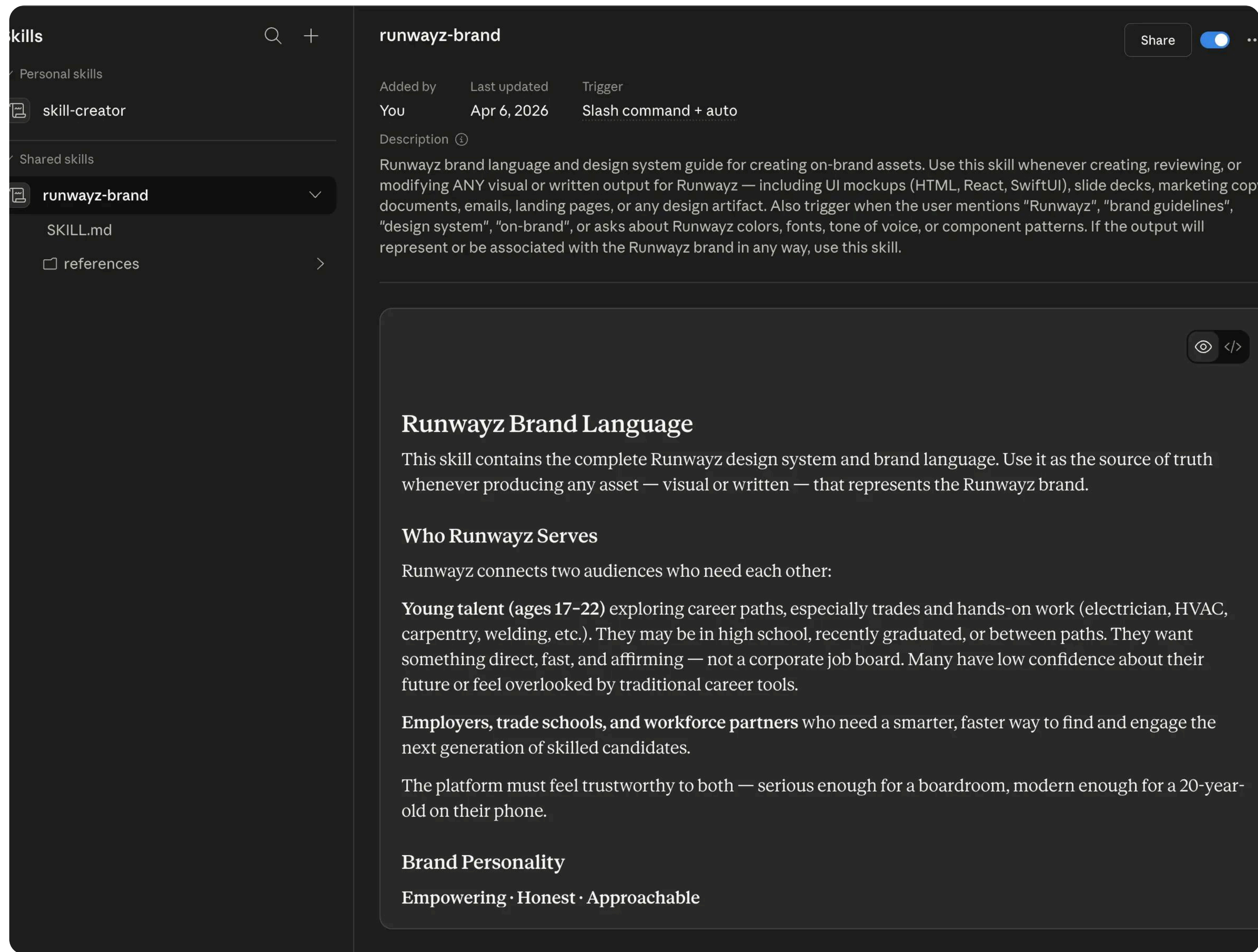


The current pipeline.

Our current pipeline wasn't bad, it was simple. Our design system lived in Figma, our primary source of truth for all new designs, components and variables.

Translating frames to our production environment was also simple - leveraging Figma's dev mode to pull all necessary CSS then rebuilding within our IDE.

Our engineering team was already leveraging Claude Code to empower development. I needed to create a flexible system that would allow our codebase to communicate with our design system.



Proceeding with caution.

My first task was to teach Claude about Runwayz. If Claude understands the brand, there would be less back and forth between myself and an AI model.

I did this by creating a skill specific to the Runwayz brand, embedded context that Claude could reference when making decisions.

My hypothesis was that, if this skill lived within our codebase, we could generate UI directly, potentially removing the need for Figma at all.

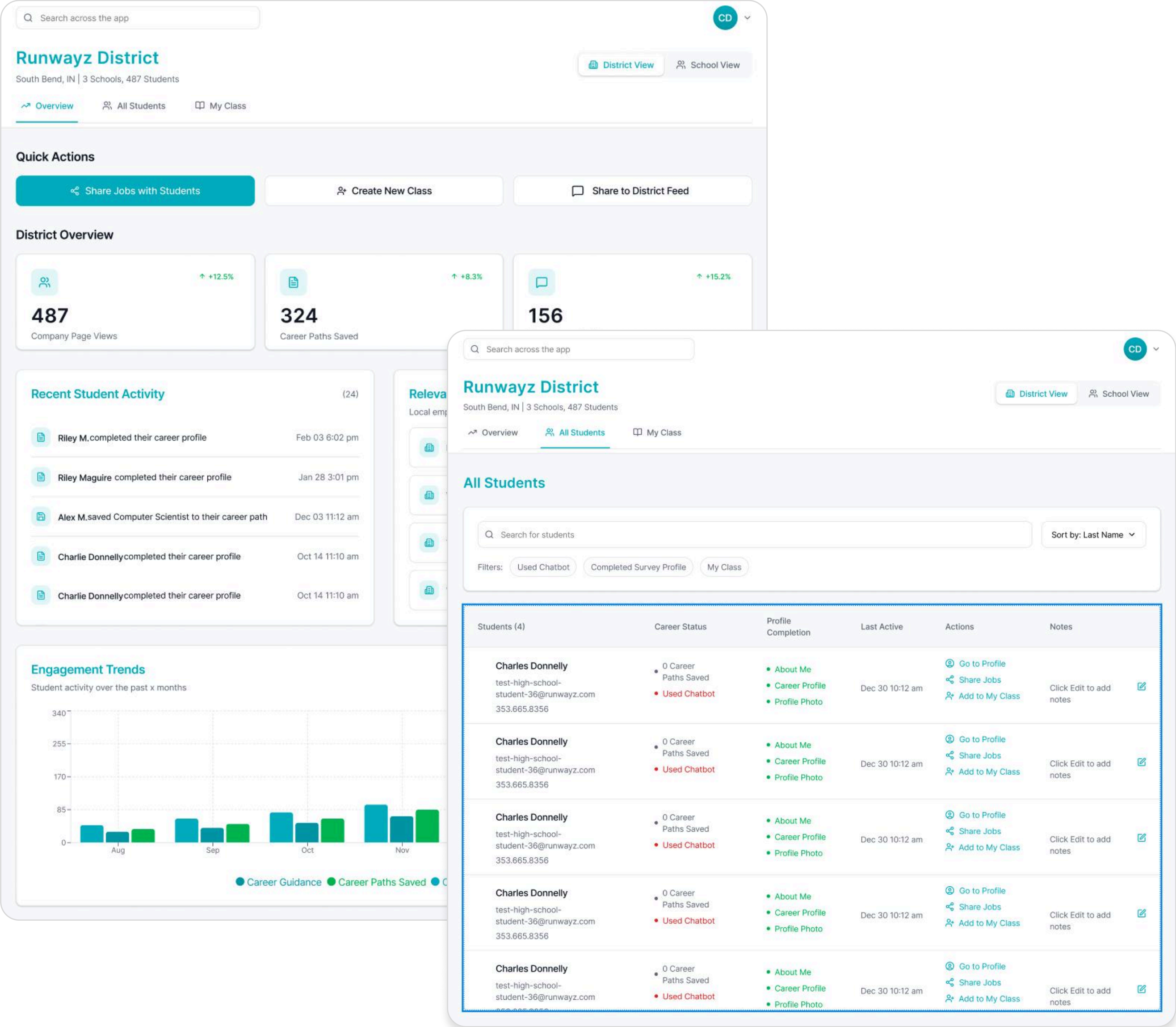


Starting too simple.

This was my first mistake. Claude + skills was effective at producing output fast, but that output was generic and hard to iterate on.

I needed a way to leverage Claude and Figma simultaneously, without sacrificing the time it takes for a developer to recreate a frame twice.

That was when I discovered the Figma MCP server.

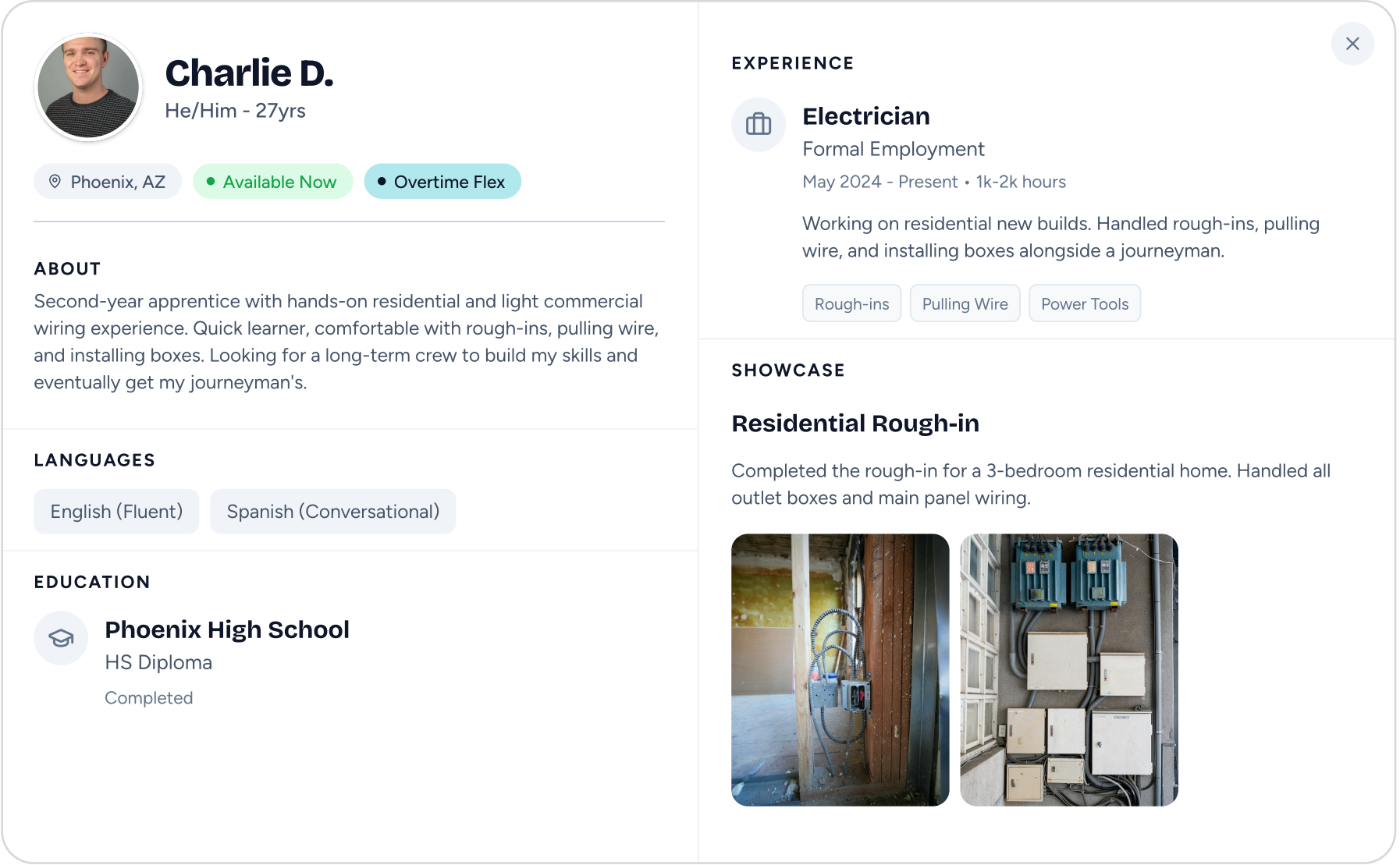
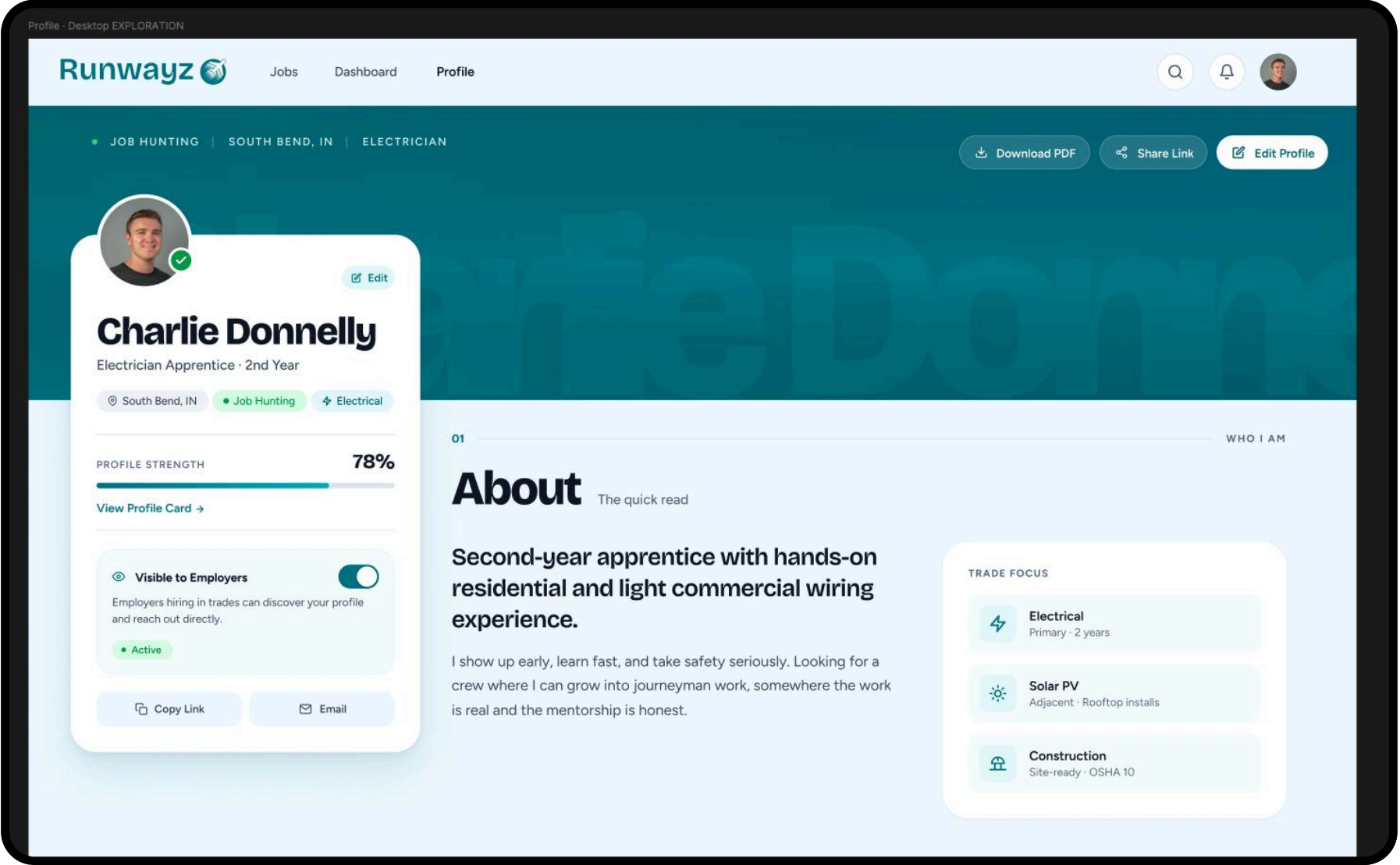


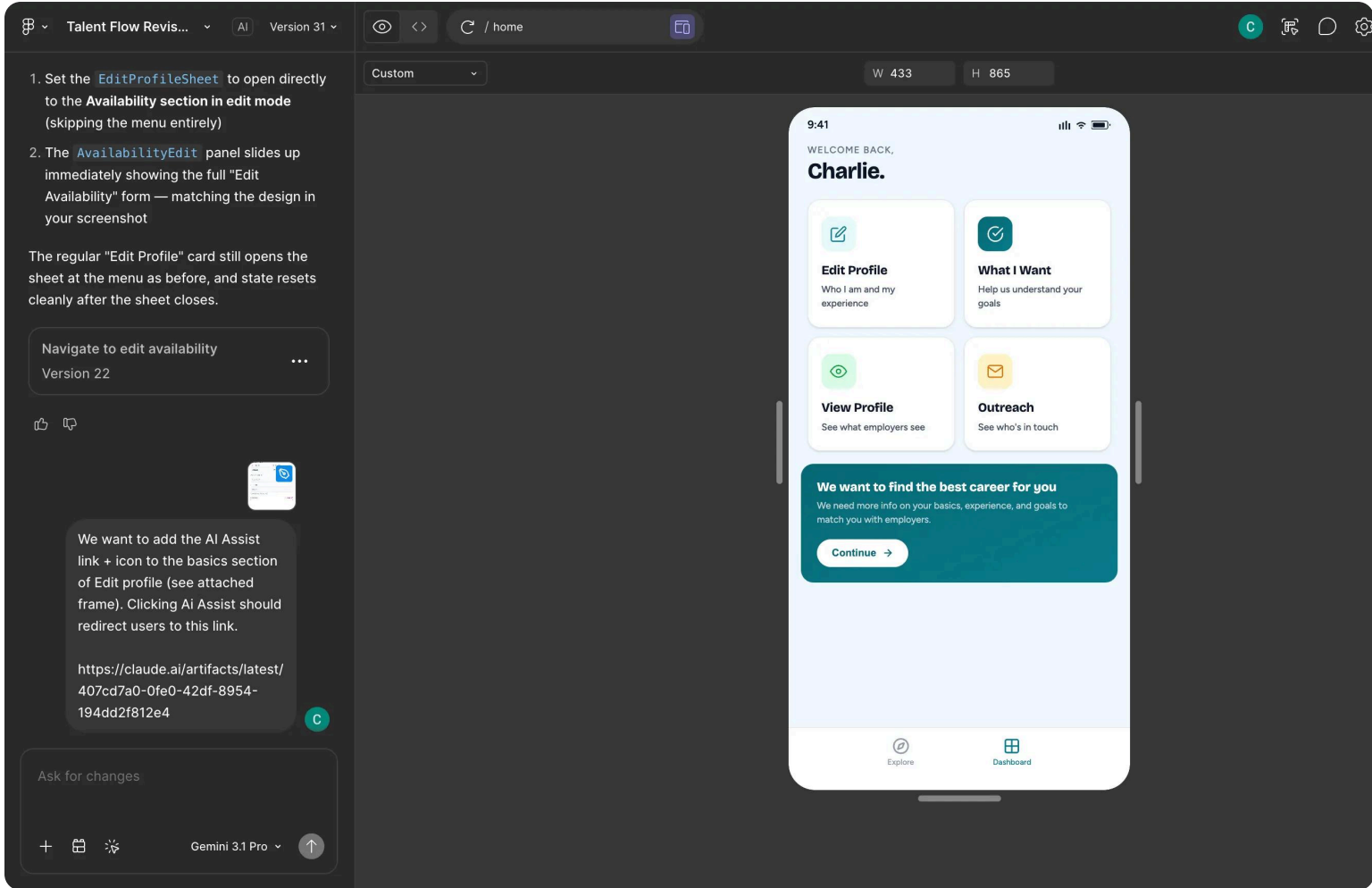
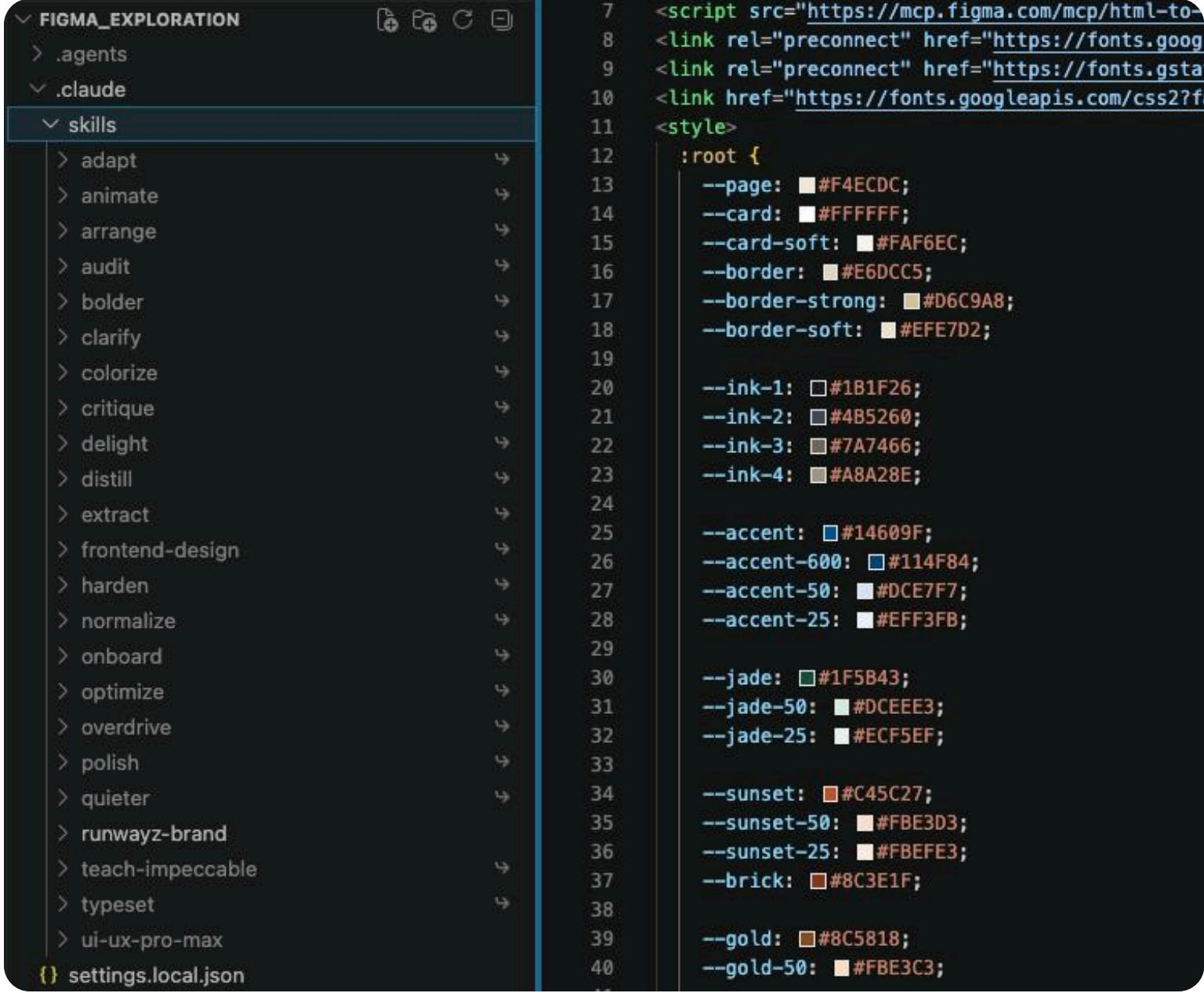
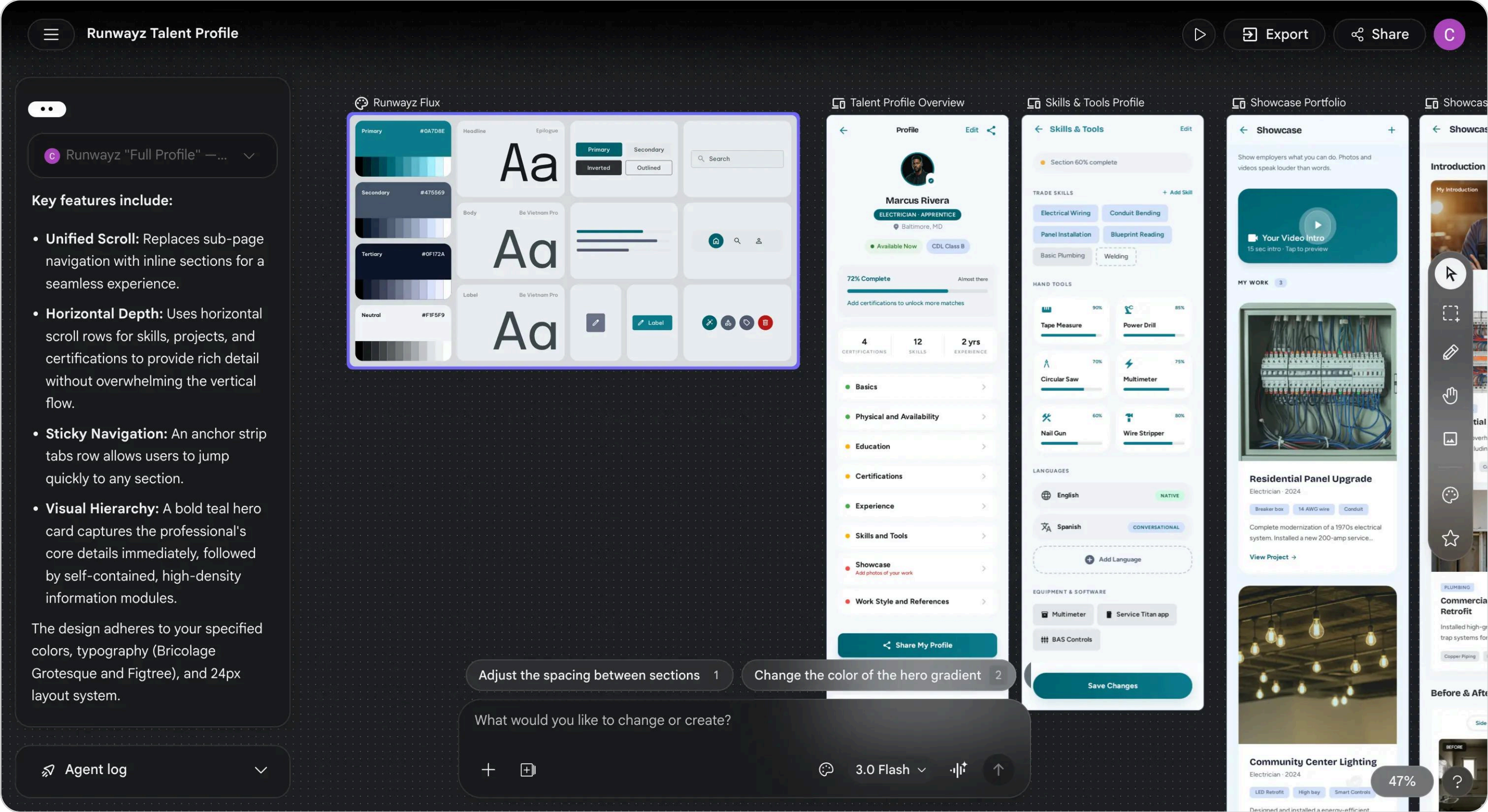
Leveling up.

Leveraging the MCP server immediately made the pipeline more flexible. I was able to iterate much faster than normal, and generating states for components was incredibly effective.

However, I still couldn't create enough distance between myself and AI. Despite my progress, the designs still had inauthentic quality to them.

I needed some more layers to my system.





Adding additional layers of nuance.

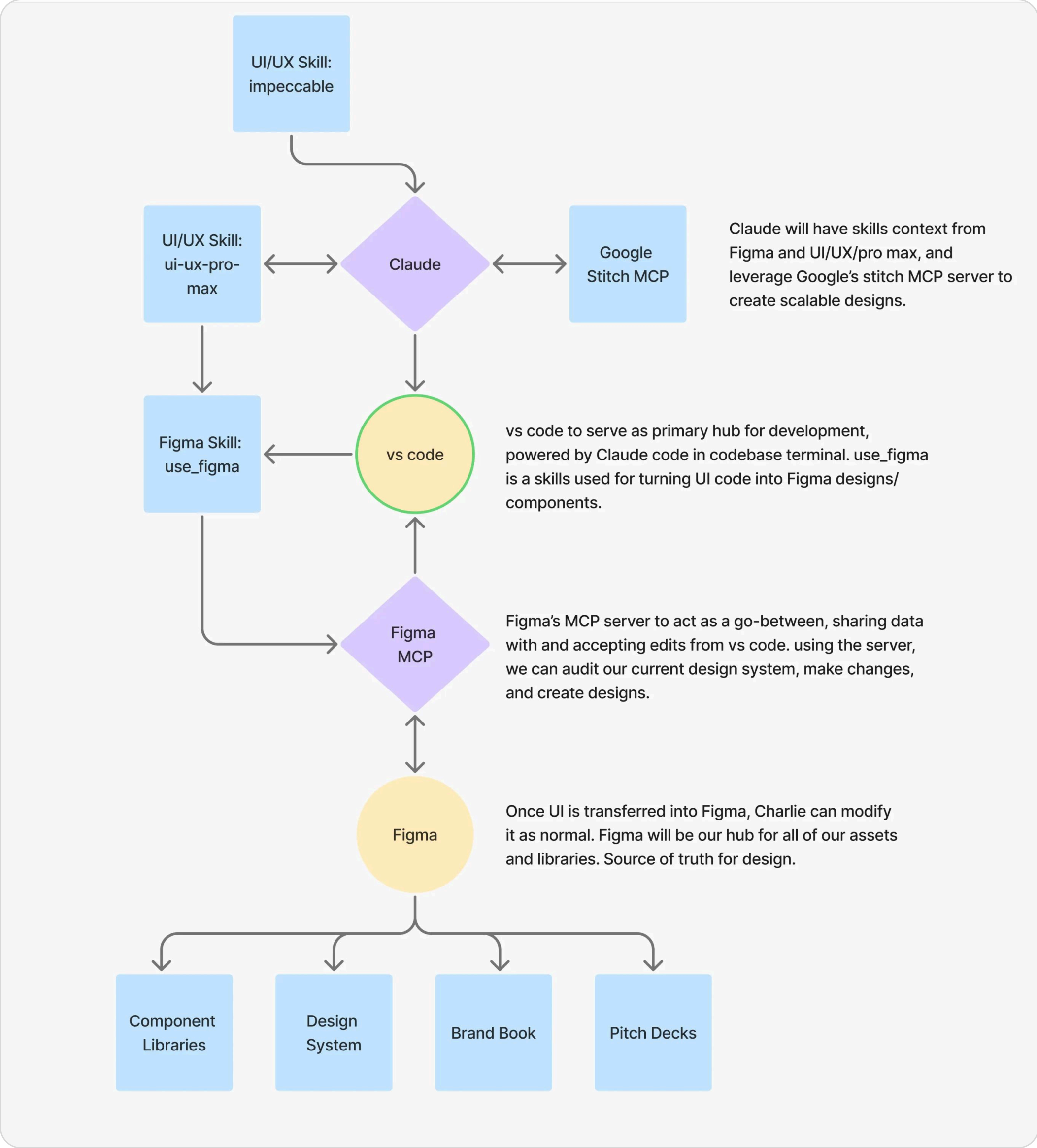
Tools like Google stitch could act as an intermediary layer between my discovery and what ultimately landed in Figma. That plus experimenting with Figma Make allowed me to have a risk-free AI layer before the final polish.



A top down overview.

I now had a clean, scalable pipeline that could be used bi-directionally. Thanks to the connection between Figma and Claude, our brand context and design system was able to be stored in one place and used globally across our pipeline.

I had everything in place just in time for someone to really push it to its limits.



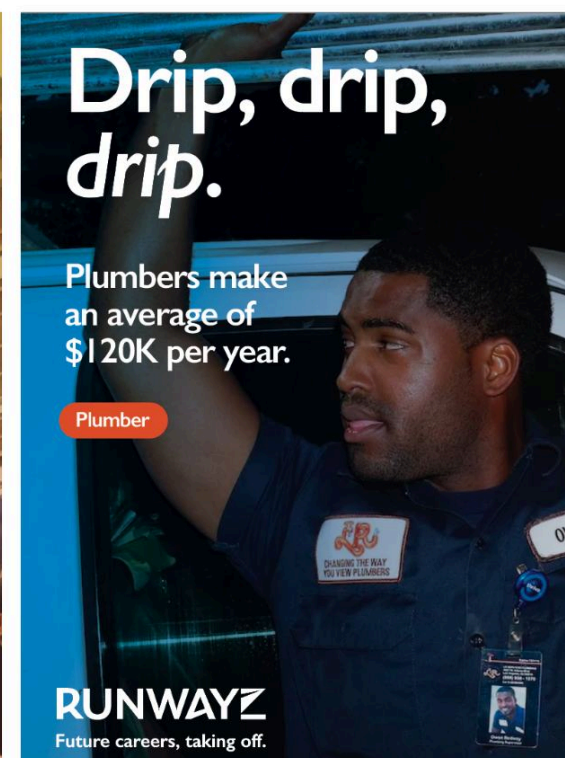
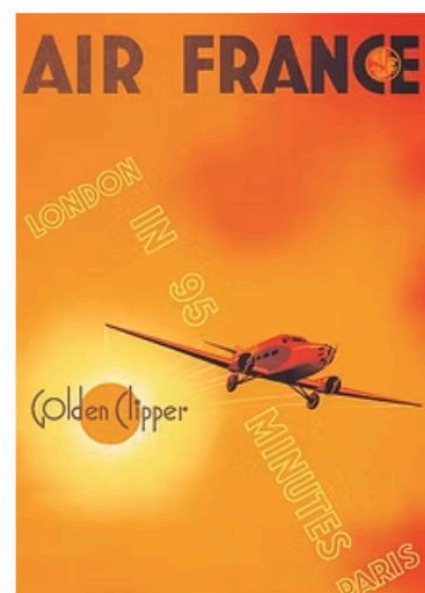
A New Design System.

Once I had our new design pipeline in a good place, our brand designer and CEO came to me with a new vision for the Runwayz brand.

Normally this would be a massive undertaking but I figured that, since I was already experimenting with an AI-empowered pipeline, I could try and overhaul our design system using the same approach.

This is when things really got interesting.

RUNWAYZ



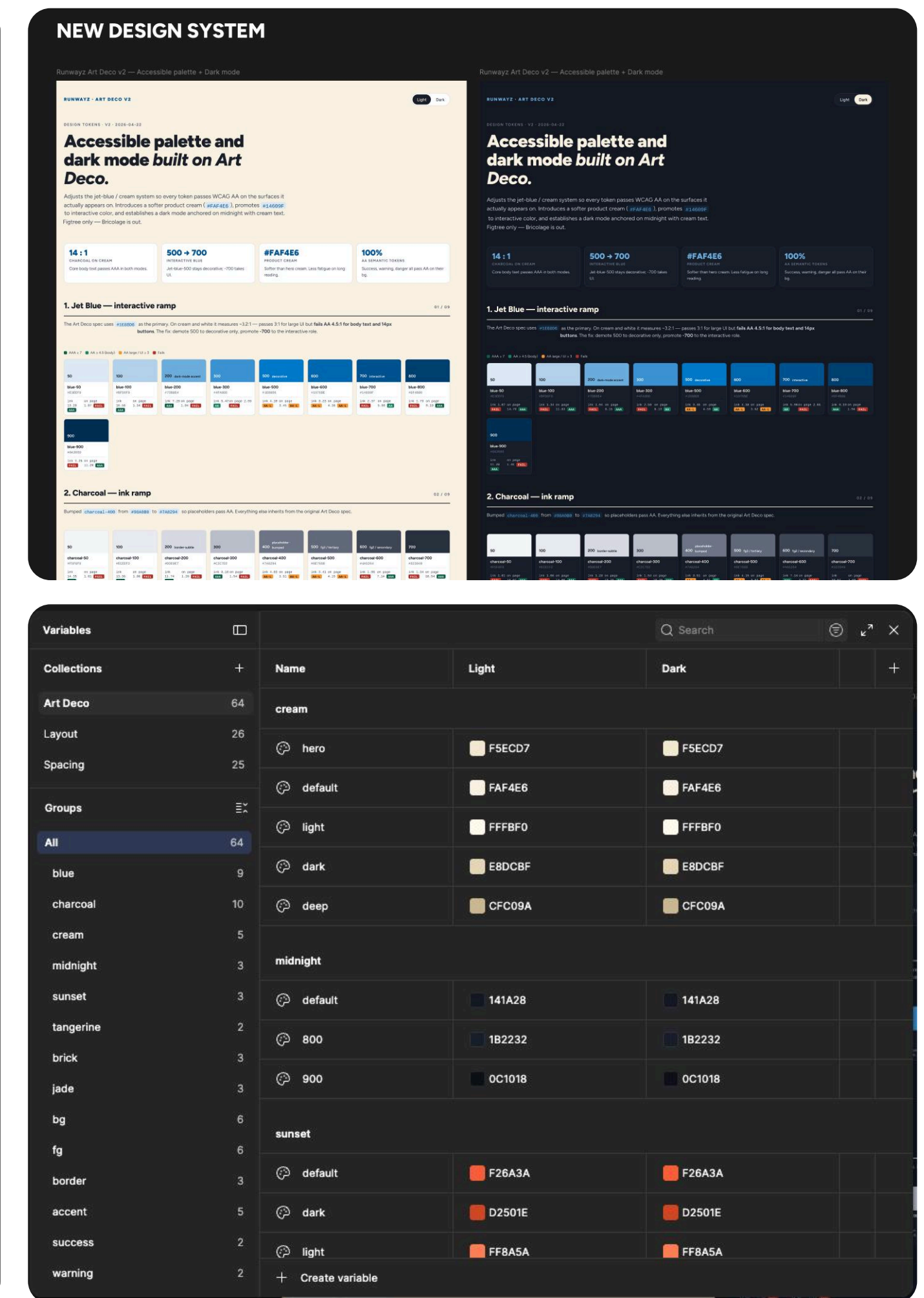
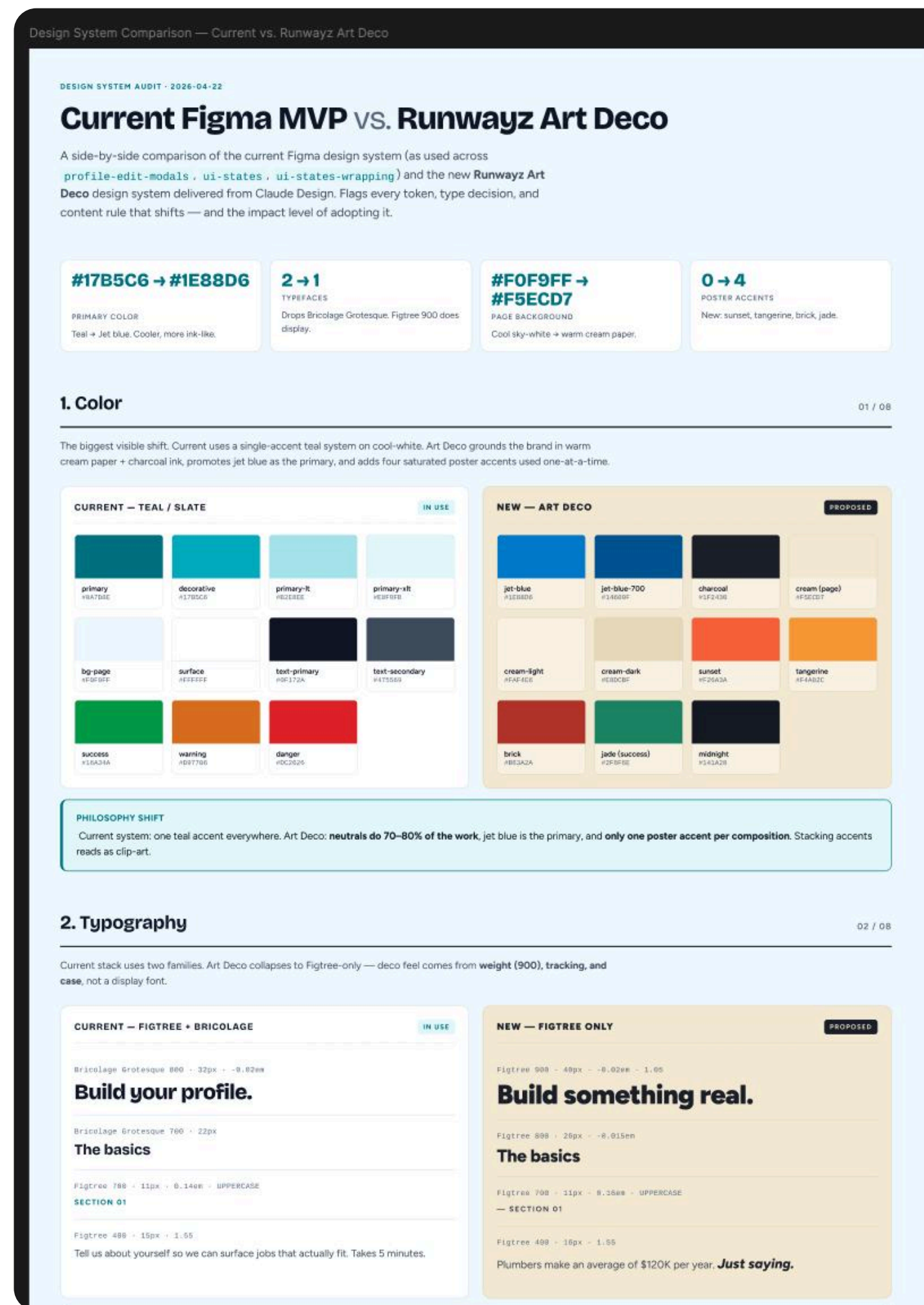
Embracing a new brand.

First, I created an audit comparison between our current system and the proposed one, checking for inconsistencies and gaps that would need to be filled.

From there, I was able to leverage the Claude → Figma pipeline to create a fully accessible color palette, and was able to replace all of our variables in Figma in one fell swoop.

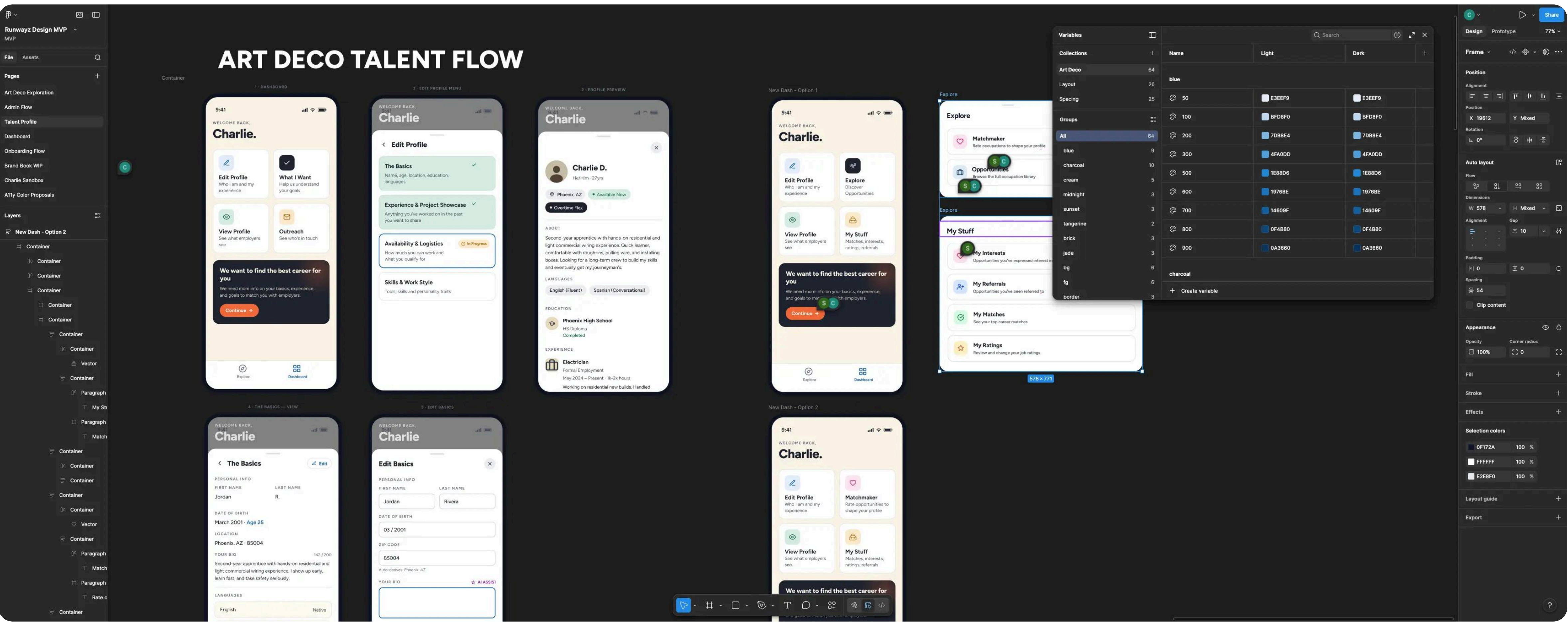
Finally, I ran a final audit against the newly created variables to create a separate dark mode palette. Once those were done, I was able to update our component library from Claude.

The whole process took me less than a day.



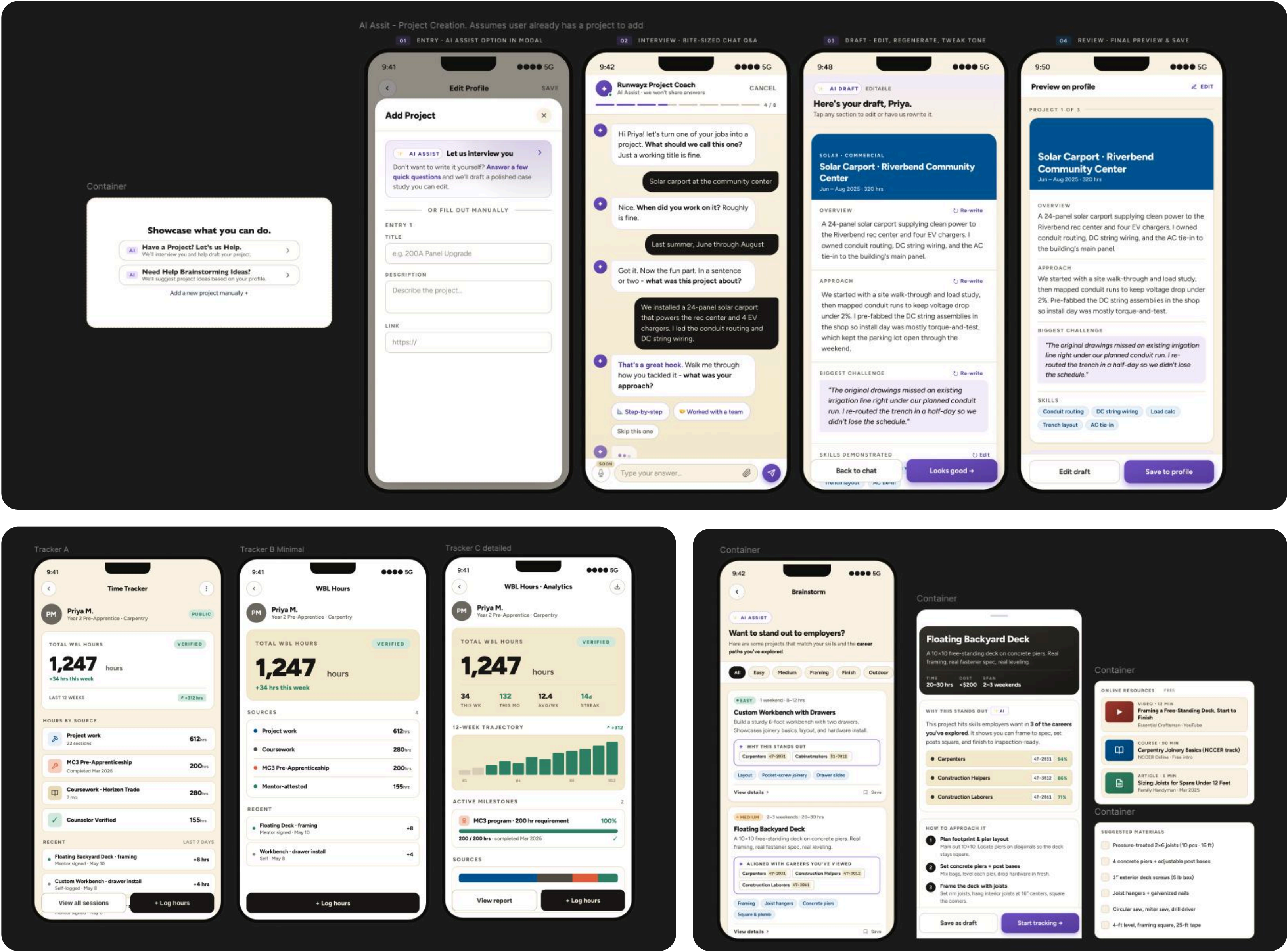
The new normal.

Once the design system had been overhauled, the pipeline was fully operational. We were able to discover, sketch, wireframe and iterate 10x faster than we had previously. *Since the workflow is bi-directional, engineering handoff was just as seamless.*



Iteration made easy.

Once we had initial wireframes for core discovery features, the new pipeline was able to streamline iteration and generating test data for demos.



Key Learnings & Insights

As I continue to experiment with and iterate on this model, it is important to emphasize *the value of human touch points* throughout the process.

The pipeline is great for *quick wins, iterations, audits, cleanup and high-level discovery*. The human is still very necessary at every step.

When done in the right way, AI can truly *unlock deep potential on design teams at scale*.

